

TECHNICAL REPORT WRITING (TRW) (Basics)

CHAPTER NO 3

Technical writing Process

Chapter 3 in a Nutshell

- You have to plan, draft and edit your document either by yourself or in a group.
- Like all processes, document production proceeds in stages. This chapter explains each of the steps involved in these stages.

Things to discuss and learn

- What is a process?
- Why is technical writing (generation of any document) a process?
- Three stages involved in the process and the details

An overview of the process

The goal of the writing process is to generate a clear and effective document that allows an audience to act. This goal should be achieved by performing activities in the following three stages:

1. Pre writing Stage: Plan by discovering and collecting all the relevant information about the communication situation and deciding what steps to follow.
2. Writing Stage: Draft and revise by selecting and arranging all the elements in the document.
3. Post writing Stage: Finish by editing the document into final form.

Planning your document

★ (Pre writing stage)

- Depending on the situation, planning can be brief or lengthy. You answer a set of questions regarding your audience, your message, your document's format and the time available. The answers to these questions provide important information about the audience and your document.
- To plan effectively, you should consider the audience and your goal as a writer (chapter 2) determine constraints, choose an effective strategy and develop a production schedule.

What constraints affect this situation?

Constraints are factors or variables that affect the production of the document. The following constraints are faced by a writer:

- Time
- Length
- Budget
- Method of production
- Method of distribution
- Place of use

Choose an effective strategy

Strategy is a plan to achieve a goal. Strategy is your 'creative concept' the way you present the material so that your reader can easily grasp it and act and it also involves the visual logic you will use.

Should you use a Genre? It means a style or category of art, music or literature. Here it means a standardized way to present information in any mode with socially agreed upon conventions, developed over time.

Develop a style sheet

A style sheet describes your page format, specifying how you will present each item of format. It is the overall planning of the format of the document in the form of a word document. It helps the writer establish and maintain a consistent visual logic for the readers and it contains information about the:

- Font sizes and font styles
- Placement of page numbers
- Lines and spacing and width of margins
- Headers and footers
- Treatment of visual aids

Develop a production schedule

It is the chronological list of activities required to generate a document and the time they will consume. The writer should ask questions like:

- How much time do I have?
- Who else is involved in the production of the document?

Choose devices to help your reader

★ (Writing stage)

- For an audience with little prior knowledge about the topic (Lay audience) use the familiar to explain the unfamiliar.
- For readers familiar with the topic (Expert audience) don't belabor the basics and use the accepted terminology.
- For all readers, do the following:
- State your purpose explicitly (use a broad and general statement)
- Make the topic of each section or paragraph/chunk clear. Use top down method, use heads, use topic sentences; top down method.
- Use the same terminology throughout and do not confuse the reader by changing names.
- Write clear sentences, shorter sentences (under 25 words), rely on active voice, employ parallelism and use words, the reader understands.

Use context setting introductions

- Provide an overall framework in the beginning while introducing readers to a topic. This is inline with the classical rule of technical writing which says, 'tell the readers what you want to tell them and then tell that thing.' This can be done in one of three ways:
 - a. Define terms
 - b. Tell what caused you to write
 - c. State the document's purpose

Place important material at the top

- Placing important material at the top, which means in the beginning of a section or a paragraph, emphasizes its importance. This strategy gives readers the ***context*** and they know what to look for as they read further.
- Put statements of significance,
- definitions and
- key terms in the beginning.

Use preview lists

A preview list contains the key words to be used in the document. It gives a sense of the document's organization. A basic list has three components:

An introductory sentence that ends in a control word

A colon

A series of items

Use repetition and sequencing

Repetition means restating or explaining the key words from the preview list that the writer has already given.

Sequencing means restating or explaining the key words *in the same order or sequence* in the text as in the list.

Use structural parallelism

It means that each section of a document follows the same organizational pattern because readers react positively once they realize the logic of the structure you are presenting.

Editing

★ (Post writing stage)

It means developing a consistent and accurate text by changing the document until it is right. The writer checks:

- Spelling
- Punctuation
- Basic grammar
- Format of page
- Accuracy of facts

(The key is to work on only one type of problem at a time)

After all these stages, the document is printed and submitted